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Blue-collar temporary agency workers' social interactions and relations, workplace social support and occupational well-being in different work arrangements: a qualitative study of the Swedish manufacturing industry

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ABSTRACT

Temporary agency work is growing in European countries. Blue-collar temporary agency workers (BC-TAWs) in the manufacturing industry are described as subject to unfavourable work conditions and low occupational well-being. While social interaction and support are important for occupational well-being, research on the impact of different work arrangements on these factors is lacking. This critical realist-informed study, employing a qualitative study design, used 24 interviews conducted at seven client organisations to explore BC-TAWs' social interaction, support, and occupational well-being in different work arrangements. Our findings show that different work arrangements either promote or hinder social interaction and support. Social support and interaction between BC-TAWs and other workers within semi- and non-Tayloristic work arrangements were associated with favouring occupational well-being, whereas counter-supportive social interaction within Tayloristic work arrangements was associated with impairing occupational well-being. This knowledge is important for both temporary work agencies and industrial client organisations to improve occupational well-being and mitigate negative health and safety consequences, particularly within Tayloristic arrangements, with less social interaction.

IMPACT STATEMENT

This study shows how different work arrangements either promote or hinder social interaction and social support. Client organisations should strive for semi- and non-Tayloristic work arrangements to promote blue-collar temporary agency workers' and other workers' well-being and, thereby, possibly also the organisational production.

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1. Introduction

Since the early 1990s, temporary work agencies in Sweden have provided industrial organisations with temporary agency workers (Competence Agencies of Sweden, 2023). While the role of management for blue-collar temporary agency workers' (BC-TAW) well-being has been well documented, the consequences of different types of industrial work arrangements remain unexplored (Hünefeld et al., 2020). BC-TAWs perform manual labour such as assembly, welding, forklift driving, loading and unloading, etc. BC-TAWs are the temporary work agencies' employees while working within an industrial plant, acquiring the labour force from the agencies. Hence, the industrial plant is referred to as the (temporary work agencies') client organisation. Thus, temporary work agencies supply the labour force while the client organisations dictate the labour tasks. This dynamic forms a triangular relationship, wherein the temporary agency workers are simultaneously linked to temporary work agencies as employees with fellow workers

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within the agency and among the client organisations' employees (Competence Agencies of Sweden, 2023). These relationships give rise to social interactions that may be important for BC-TAW's perceived social support and occupational well-being, and, in the long run, also for company health and safety (Hasle & Møller, 2007).

Industrial client organisations occupy more than 20% of all temporary agency workers in Sweden (Competence Agencies of Sweden, 2019). Further, temporary agency work is growing in European countries (Storrie, 2017), and is, in general, assumed to be more precarious and less favourable than permanent work. Previous research has shown that BC-TAWs are poorly introduced to their work and no investments are made in their competence development (Håkansson & Isidorsson, 2012), while they are expected to blend into the existing work organisation and show commitment to their work (Augustsson, 2014). BC-TAWs' poor introduction to work and workplace safety (Underhill & Quinlan, 2011) constitutes an increased health risk, which is amplified by their peripheral position in the workplace that has been characterised as being at the bottom of the hierarchy (Bosmans, De Cuyper, et al., 2015; Bosmans, Hardonk, et al., 2015; Nielsen et al., 2019) and outside the core working force (Bosmans, De Cuyper, et al., 2015; Bosmans, Hardonk, et al., 2015; Boyce et al., 2007). While BC-TAWs have been stigmatised as second-grade workers, they can also be perceived as a threat to permanent employees in industrial client organisations (Boyce et al., 2007; Imhof & Andresen, 2018). This may be due to BC-TAWs working harder and faster, either for proving their worth or of for being replaced.

BC-TAWs' less favourable working conditions and their consequences for BC-TAWs' mental health have been studied previously (Hünefeld et al., 2020; Underhill & Quinlan, 2011). Research highlights the benefits of perceived social support (e.g. performance feedback) on BC-TAWs' occupational well-being as well as on their commitment to the client organisation and safety behaviour (Cicellin et al., 2022; Clarke et al., 2016, p. 95; Imhof & Andresen, 2017). In addition, the role of management for BC-TAWs' well-being (e.g. production leaders and temporary work agency managers) has been well documented (Augustsson, 2012; Augustsson et al., 2010; Kjörling et al., 2024). Workplace social support has been found to benefit BC-TAWs' occupational well-being (Frederick & VanderWeele, 2020), and typically, BC-TAWs 'respond with a positive attitude towards an organisation that shows that it values the contribution of [BC-]TAWs and cares about their well-being' (Giunchi et al., 2015, p. 20). However, social interaction and social support may be limited due to different types of work arrangements in industrial settings. A systematic review by Hünefeld et al. (2020) raised the need to study the work design to understand how the relationships between temporary agency workers and their mental health can be enhanced. In addition, we have not found any studies on BC-TAWs' social interactions and social support in different work arrangements.

Through the two following research question we contribute to addressing the above identified gap:

a. *How do BC-TAWs in different work arrangements describe their social interaction with other workers at the client organisation?*
b. *How do social interaction and perceived workplace social support from other workers relate to BC-TAWs' occupational well-being?*

The purpose of this qualitative study is to explore how different work arrangements within the Swedish manufacturing industry may impact BC-TAWs' social interaction with other workers, including client organisation employees and other BC-TAWs, and further, the effects of social interaction on BC-TAWs' perceived workplace social support and occupational well-being.

1.1. Theory

This study is critical-realist informed, which means that it seeks to explain the social events and empirical patterns by identifying their underlying mechanisms and surrounding structures (Elder-Vass, 2010; Lawson, 2012). In this study, we focus on BC-TAWs' patterned social interactions with other workers and explore their underlying mechanisms and the structural work arrangements in which they are embedded. The latter are primarily understood as socio-technical work arrangements in industrial settings combining human and machine, for example, on the assembly line (Elder-Vass, 2017; Kjörling

et al., 2024). Although our focus is on these specific interactions, relations, mechanisms and work arrangements within client organisations, we acknowledge that BC-TAWs' position is shaped by the broader social and institutional structures of the Swedish manufacturing industry in which it is embedded. We employ the broad concepts of workplace social support (Jolly et al., 2021; Thoits, 2011) and occupational well-being (Van Horn et al., 2004) to describe the social interactions and relations between BC-TAWs and other workers of client organisations.

Workplace social support refers to 'psychological or material resources that are provided to a focal individual by partners in some form of social relationship' (Jolly et al., 2021). It is a broad construct that describes a network of social and material resources perceived by an individual in the workplace and performs the three functions: *emotional* (demonstration of love, care, appraisal, feedback, sympathy, etc.); *instrumental* (giving a helping hand, offering behavioural or material assistance, etc.); and *informational* (know-how, instructions, help with problem-solving, etc.) (Thoits, 2011, p. 146). Thoits (2011) argues that social support promotes and buffers well-being through the mechanisms of social influence/social comparison, social control, role-based purpose and meaning (mattering), self-esteem, sense of control, belonging and companionship and perceived support availability.

Following Kossek et al. (2011), workplace social support in this study is understood as (i) content-specific relating to a particular occupational position of the individual, such as BC-TAW, and (ii) emanating from multiple sources, such as BC-TAWs' coworkers within client organisations (Kossek et al., 2011). We also expect the broader social context—including rules, regulations and hierarchical positions, as well as material work arrangements—to both enable and constrain socially supportive interactions in a workplace.

Well-being may be described as 'a positive state experienced by individuals and […] a resource for daily life [that] is determined by social, economic and environmental conditions' (Nutbeam & Muscat, 2021). The concept of well-being is understood as multi-dimensional (Charalampous et al., 2019), yet domain-specific, like occupational well-being (Van Horn et al., 2004), which is the subject matter of this study. According to Van Horn et al. (2004), the dimensions of occupational well-being include *affective* (commitment to work, job satisfaction and lack of emotional exhaustion), *professional* (competence, aspiration and autonomy) and *social* (quality of social functioning and lack of depersonalization) along with *cognitive* (lack of cognitive weariness) and *psychosomatic* (lack of psychosomatic complaints, such as headaches or back pains) well-being. Thereby, occupational well-being is dependent on the contexts of work arrangements and the workplace social support enabled by them.

In terms of industrial settings, work arrangements may be understood as Tayloristic, semi-Tayloristic and non-Tayloristic (Braverman et al., 1999, p. 59), which are associated with different degrees of BC-TAWs' flexibility and perceived autonomy (Pateman, 1970). *Tayloristic work arrangements* (e.g. an assembly line characterised by high quantitative work demands in cycles of minutes) leave little room for BC-TAW autonomy. *Semi-Tayloristic work arrangements* (e.g. an assembly line with moderate quantitative demands in cycles of hours) offer some flexibility and autonomy, while *non-Tayloristic work arrangements* allow BC-TAWs' ability to plan and undertake work tasks in cycles of days, typically requiring high qualitative demands. The contrastive affordances of these different work arrangements may, therefore, have a significant impact on the perceived social support and well-being of the BC-TAWs who work within these arrangements.

2. Method

The study employs a critical realism-informed qualitative study design, providing a sensitivity to context-specific variations when seeking theory-related explanations (Modell, 2009; Mukumbang, 2023). This implied gathering qualitative data on BC-TAWs social interactions and relations within different work arrangements, i.e. Tayloristic, semi-Tayloristic and non-Tayloristic, with the aim of describing the quality of these interactions and relations, as well as exploring and theorizing the underlying mechanisms that govern them (Schoonenboom & Johnson, 2017; Turner et al., 2017).

2.1. Participants and data collection

Using a convenient sample and snowball selection, 24 BC-TAWs; 11 females and 13 males, aged 19–57 were engaged. The participants' time spent on the current assignment at the client organisation ranged

from a few weeks to 11 years. The interviewees were located in seven different sites and recruited with support from the local union organisations. Before commencing the interviews, all interviewees filled out a written informed consent to participate in the study (ALLEA, 2017).

All interviews were conducted in Swedish, on-site (with the exception of one phone interview), at seven different client organisations, and lasted 30–60 min. The interviews were sound recorded and transcribed verbatim by the corresponding author and followed a semi-structured format of open-ended questions dealing with, for example, the nature of BC-TAWs' undertaken work (informing us on the type of work-arrangement), BC-TAWs' relations to other workers (informing us on social interactions and relations), and BC-TAWs' ability to ask for help (informing us on workplace social support). At most sites, the interviewing researcher (No name) were also given a tour of the client organisations' industrial plant, facilitating the interviews by enabling mutual references (e.g. work arrangements) with the interviewees. The interviewed BC-TAWs were also asked to describe their typical working day, to recall an occasion (if such existed) when they felt particularly bad and particularly good about themselves (informing us on perceived occupational well-being).

2.2. Data analyses, retroduction and identification of mechanisms

The data were thematically analysed (Fryer, 2022; Wiltshire & Ronkainen, 2021) using the software ATLAS.ti. We identified relevant social interactions and relations, norms, mechanisms and socio-technical arrangements from the interviewee testimonies, cf. Edwards et al. (2014, 312), using the backwards process of *retroduction* (Downward & Mearman, 2006; Iannacci et al., 2023; Lawson, 2012). Retroduction is a fallible inference from observed phenomena (e.g. specific events or patterns) to the description of underlying structures and mechanisms that may generate them and, thereby, explain them. In practice, retroductive analysis takes the form of "a continuous, spiral movement between the abstract and the concrete, between theoretical and empirical work, involving both an interpretive and a causal dimension of explanation" (Mukumbang, 2023).

Thus, 69 codes were generated, labelling descriptions of the social phenomena (Elder-Vass, 2010, p. 71); experiences of counter-supportive and supportive social interaction and relations in different work arrangements. Further, emotional, instrumental, and informational workplace social support, qualitative and quantitative job demands, as well as affective, professional and social well-being were labelled.

After every five transcriptions, transcripts were coded, quotes were sourced and added to a growing memo containing summaries along with the researchers' thoughts on the matter at hand through constant comparison (Fletcher, 2017; Hoddy, 2019; Oliver, 2012). As blocks of text were coded with several codes, a code co-occurrence analysis was conducted in ATLAS.ti, aiding the overall analyses.

Finally, two types of underlying mechanisms governing BC-TAWs' social interactions and relations were also theorised (Edwards et al., 2014, p. 91) by utilising the results of earlier research: (i) the counter-supportive mechanisms of *mistrust* (Lanaj et al., 2018), *disparity* (Greenberg, 2011; Kjörling et al., 2024), and *aggression* (Birkeland Nielsen et al., 2015), typically operating within Tayloristic work arrangements, and (ii) the supportive mechanisms of *trust* (Hall, 2016), *relatedness* (Halbesleben, 2010; Wrzesniewski & Dutton, 2001), *and care* (Thoits, 2011), typically operating within semi-Tayloristic and non-Tayloristic work arrangements (Table 1). These supportive and counter-supportive mechanisms governing BC-TAWs' social interactions and relations in different work arrangements are important for explaining the empirical patterns in BC-TAWs' perceived social support and occupational well-being.

This study adheres to the Declaration of Helsinki (The World Medical Association, 2024). Following national Swedish law, ethical approval was obtained from the Swedish Ethical Review Authority (Ref No 2019, 06220; 2022-05554-02).

3. Results

This study showed that BC-TAWs' ability to interact with other workers, for both BC-TAWs and client organisation employees, depended on both the site and nature of the work undertaken, that is, the type of work arrangement. We found that, depending on the type of work arrangement (Tayloristic, semi- and

Table 1. Table showing description of underlying mechanisms governing counter-supportive and supportive relations.

	Description
Underlying mechanisms governing counter-supportive relations	
Mistrust	Refers to beliefs of ill intent and lack of reliability among the workers (Lanaj et al., 2018).
Disparity	Refers to normative categories of us and them manifested in unequal and unfair treatment (Greenberg, 2011; Kjörling et al., 2024).
Aggression	Refers to abuse such as bullying, harassment, trash talk within the work place (Birkeland Nielsen et al., 2015)
Underlying mechanisms governing supportive relations	
Trust	Refers to beliefs in good intent and a mutual ability to rely on fellow workers (Hall, 2016).
Relatedness	Refers to the ability to relate to the client organisation and actively engage in the work undertaken (Halbesleben, 2010; Wrzesniewski & Dutton, 2001).
Care	Refers to workers' mutual interest in others' occupational well-being manifested through expressed concern and encouragement (Thoits, 2011).

non-Tayloristic), social interaction was either counter-supportive (e.g. bullying and abusing), impairing occupational well-being, or supportive (e.g. helping and trustful), constituting either counter-supportive or supportive social relations, favouring occupational well-being.

To highlight the qualitative differences, often overlooked in quantitative analysis, we have classified social interactions as either counter-supportive or supportive and, accordingly, social relations as either counter-supportive or supportive.

The disposition of the results will show the findings in text format with quotes to answer the research questions. A summary is offered at the end of the sections for social interaction and relations (3.1.3) and social support and occupational well-being (3.2.4).

3.1. Social interactions and relations in different work arrangements

Depending on work arrangements, social interaction may take place not only during breaks but also during working time. One female BC-TAW, who's been at the plant for several years, albeit at different sections, described how she recognised and cared for familiar faces in the corridors and the cantina. When asked about the relationship with other workers, another BC-TAW working on the assembly line replied:

> 'You know, I think it's good! Absolutely. Maybe that is one of the reasons for sticking around despite knowing it's insecure. We're a good team' [Interviewee 05].

Social interactions also took place both during work and breaks, at the production line or in the staff canteen. While some BC-TAWs testified to only shop talk, most BC-TAWs claimed topics vary from work-related to weekend activities, cooking, the latest news or something seen on either the internet or on social media. Likewise, social interaction took place outside the factory plant while commuting to and from the factory plant, as described by one male BC-TAW working with maintenance at a factory plant:

> 'You know, you meet quite a lot. on the train also. You know, a lot of client organisation employees travel as well […]. They grab a Friday beer before going on the train. So there are a lot of people you meet' [Interviewee 08].

3.1.1. Social interactions and relations in Tayloristic work arrangements

Social interactions and relations within Tayloristic work arrangements were associated with perceived high demands and a lack of influence. Within such contexts, BC-TAWs perceived stress related to both the work tasks and to other workers on the assembly line. In the latter case, it was a question of not falling behind and thereby keeping others waiting. One female BC-TAW, working on the assembly line within a Tayloristic work arrangement, reported counter-supportive social interactions and relations, characterised by mistrust, disparity and even aggression.

Further, several BC-TAWs experienced counter-supportive social relations and were repeatedly told of their replaceability, implying that if one complains, does not meet the production quota, or in any other way is perceived as inconvenient by others, the assignment may be terminated in an instant. Hence, one BC-TAW reflected on a selfish will to excel as a cause of mistrust, blaming others:

> 'One tends to blame others, that one doesn't want to take responsibility… well.' "well, it wasn't my fault!" and then it puts pressure on the rest of us to… and if they 'don't work, then we have to do their job "o"'. [Interviewee 22].

A Tayloristic structure, however, did not rule out all social interaction. Particularly among BC-TAWs who interacted outside the client organisation's premises. This was illustrated by another female BC-TAW working in the assembly line:

> Sometimes we actually talk about the situations down on the floor, but it is very rare to dare to talk. We always talk very quietly. When we meet in the parking lot we might dare say something, exchange a few words or […] but at no place is there trust in one another, people say, well, don't trust anyone because people snitch, you know. [Interviewee 02]

3.1.2. Social interactions and relations in semi- and non-tayloristic arrangements

Social interactions and relations within semi- and non-Tayloristic work arrangements were mostly characterised by trust, care and relatedness with other BC-TAWs and client organisation employees, enabling workplace social support and a perceived influence at the client organisation. BC-TAWs perceived and reported that no particular difference was made between them and the client organisation employees. Rather, everybody considered one another to be part of the same workplace on equal terms, doing the same tasks, as described by one male BC-TAW working with logistics:

> 'Everybody talks and treats one another equally'. [Interviewee 11].

Further, influence at work, for example choosing how the work should be done was illustrated by one male BC-TAW, working in maintenance, who shared how he and other workers discussed the installation of new machinery in a dense factory plant:

> 'When we are to move in large tools and machinery with the forklift close to the machine. You know, how we will plan it […] and do it. That kind of stuff'. [Interviewee 08]

On the other hand, if the absence of social interaction is by the choice of the BC-TAW, it could also be supportive, enabling both recovery and workflow. Yet another male BC-TAW working on an assembly line, within a semi-Tayloristic work arrangement, explained how flexible work hours enabled one to stay a bit longer after the rest of the shift on a weekend and enjoy some solitary time:

> 'It's very calm and quiet there around 3–5–3.30 pm […] calm and pleasant, you know, it's like working on a weekend. No one is making noise and. pulling traverses… You know, the noise level is a bit'. [Interviewee 16]

These findings showed that a willingness to take a break from social interaction confirmed BC-TAWs' confidence in social relations and that they still experienced trust and inclusion.

3.1.3. Summary of findings on social interaction and relations

Regarding our first research question on social interaction in different work arrangements, our findings showed that Tayloristic work arrangements gave rise to perceived high quantitative demands and little or no room for autonomy. BC-TAWs working in these arrangements mostly described counter-supportive social interactions and social relations between BC-TAWs and other workers. In contrast, semi-Tayloristic and non-Tayloristic work arrangements gave rise to more autonomy and BC-TAWs mostly reported supportive social interactions and relations between BC-TAWs and other workers, and described facilitating mechanisms of trust, care and relatedness.

3.2. Workplace social support and occupational well-being

Our findings showed, in general, that Non-Tayloristic and Semi-Tayloristic work arrangements, enabled social interaction and relations, small talk and camaraderie among BC-TAWs and client organisation employees. These work arrangements fostered workplace social support and favoured BC-TAWs' occupational well-being.

BC-TAWs who reported experiencing occupational well-being also thought that it was buffered by social support and through social interaction with both other BC-TAWs and client organisation employees, providing emotional, instrumental and informational workplace social support. In contrast, the absence of workplace social support was constituted by counter-supportive social interactions and relations, and BC-TAWs reported a lack of workplace social support impaired their occupational well-being.

In Tayloristic work arrangements, BC-TAWs reported high quantitative demands, leaving little room for social interaction, and lack of workplace social support in terms of giving a helping hand (instrumental) and sharing know-how (informational) among workers, as one prefers to keep to oneself rather than entrust others. BC-TAWs reported how workers keeping to themselves rather than interacting with others caused safety problems, for example, careless driving a forklift too fast or not looking out for other workers. Equally, disparity in the workforce, manifested in feelings of not being related, was perceived to impair influence in terms of the ability to voice concerns regarding the work environment at the client organisation. A BC-TAW working on the assembly line was left alone when presented with the following complaints. What was meant to be a joint effort turned out to highlight one of BC-TAW as an inconvenient troublemaker:

> 'We joined forces and said we would take it to a production leader. I don't remember specifically what it was, but we felt it wasn't good […] but when I was standing there…' [Interviewee 03]

3.2.1. Emotional workplace social support, influence at work and occupational well-being

Emotional workplace social support and influence at work was facilitated through norms of reliability and friendliness, and BC-TAWs described the importance of social interactions with client organisation employees and other BC-TAWs for occupational well-being. Further, this made them experience affective and professional occupational well-being by feeling cheerful, being in good spirits and motivated. This was illustrated by one male BC-TAW working on an assembly line:

> It's very important. It's what often… sometimes the job can become a bit repetitive, and you just keep repeating the same thing over and over again, so it's important to have fun and pleasant… you know, good colleagues who still make you want to, keep the motivation. [Interviewee 18]

The BC-TAW also reported emotional social support from the other workers to promote social well-being:

> We joke around a lot, but at the same time, we do care about each other's health. So, everyone is doing well and enjoying themselves. We talk about work a bit too. I think it's a good relationship. A good balance between… You have to be able to have fun at work too, that's important for enjoying it. [Interviewee 18]

Another male BC-TAW, working with logistics, perceived relatedness and affective well-being when going to work:

> 'I'm very happy to come here. I am… overjoyed. Not like, oh, I wake up in the morning and don't have any strength, I'm hurting, I have to… No, no, no, I wake up every morning energized, happy to go to work. Because I like it a lot'. [Interviewee 14]

Several BC-TAWs considered emotional workplace social support important when voicing work-related concerns. This was illustrated by one female BC-TAW working on an assembly line:

> 'You can team up first and see what the others think and if others are agreeing about it, then it's easier to tell the boss'. (Interviewee 17)

In contrast, the absence of emotional workplace social support was described as insufficient help, i.e. lack of instrumental social support combined with high qualitative job demands, diminished affective and professional well-being and was illustrated by one male BC-TAW recalling an assembly line at a previous assignment:

> 'Some people who are to instruct somebody say to do this, do that and then leave. And then the person is standing there, might have really low self-esteem and be really sad'. [Interviewee 08]

Equally, if left alone with a heavy workload, lack of workplace social support was reported to diminish the ability to exercise influence, experience well-being and instead increased the risk of BC-TAWs' perceived exhaustion and workplace risks. Without influence, the situation may be very tiring and as illustrated by one female BC-TAW working with logistics. She told about how she was filling in for a tall guy:

> It's a lot of heavy lifts, it is. I've been telling now cause […] well, we pack in large carts that can weigh quite a lot and should be lifted over the frame of a pallet […] And the regular guy, he's tall (laughter). He's two meters tall, and I'm not very tall at all. […] But nothing has happened. [Interviewee 10]

3.2.2. Instrumental workplace social support and occupational well-being

Instrumental workplace social support, such as the ability to ask for help, was considered important among BC-TAWs for their occupational well-being, not least because a high workload could impair commitment to safety procedures and thereby decrease social well-being. This is illustrated by the description of one male BC-TAW:

> Alone here is not strong […] it can become quite a lot of time pressure. eh. so then it is very important to ask one another for help and. so that you. at the end of the day, the orders need to be delivered, and if I bust my ass alone or if I can work in a more comfortable tempo, that's. yeah. [Interviewee 15]

When BC-TAWs described instrumental workplace social support, it was in interactions and relations with other BC-TAWs, that they were looking after one another and were able to ask for help. This was illustrated by one male BC-TAW working on the assembly line:

> If you do right and feel sure of your task, and then, if you do it more and more times, you at last become self-secure. I know that I'm doing right. If you don't ask, then maybe you're standing there believing that. what you do is right and it's not… You don't gain the same experience and the same self-esteem. [Interviewee 12]

BC-TAWs described occupational well-being (affective, social, cognitive and psychosomatic) as feeling both physically and socially safe at work when BC-TAWs and client organisation employees look after one another. This was typically the case where BC-TAWs had assignments stretching over a longer time, wore the same clothes as client organisation employees, and thereby, in reality, constituted a more permanent part of the client organisation workforce. This was illustrated by one female BC-TAW working on the assembly line:

> When you're on an assignment for a longer period, it will be really good. Because then you feel included, you experience a connection with the people on-site and. you gain friends, you know, colleagues as we call it. [Interviewee 01]

3.2.3. Informational workplace social support and occupational well-being

Informational workplace social support and influence, such as the ability to ask for knowledge and instructions, by other BC-TAWs and client organisation employees were important factors for cognitive, professional and social occupational well-being. Asking for help in problem-solving, from other BC-TAWs or client organisation employees, was not only in the interest of performing the work tasks correctly, but also to keep other workers from being annoyed by errors. One BC-TAW working in the assembly line explained:

> 'Everybody needs help at some point […] You can tell who's asking for help and who's making the mistakes'. [Interviewee 16]

Being able to ask for know-how was beneficial for BC-TAW's mastery, thereby enhancing their affective, social and cognitive well-being, as described by one BC-TAW working with logistics:

> They treat you like you'd like to be treated yourself and you can count on them if there is some problem, or… You know, that you can be honest and talk to them about. it should be possible to talk if there's a problem, I think you should be able to solve it within the group, you know, without taking it higher. [Interviewee 11]

3.2.4. Summary of findings on workplace social support and BC-TAWs' occupational well-being

In regard to our second research question on social support and occupational well-being, our findings showed that BC-TAWs perceived emotional workplace social support through norms of reliability and friendliness, instrumental workplace social support by looking after one another and ask for help and informational social support by being able to ask for know-how, and that support was related to occupational well-being. Further, social support in Tayloristic work arrangements was reported as being inhibited by counter-supportive social interactions and relations. In contrast, semi and non-Tayloristic work arrangements fostered supportive social interactions and relations which were governed by mechanisms of trust, relatedness and care. Thus, this explains BC-TAWs perceptions of high workplace social support and occupational well-being.

4. Discussion

In this critical realist-informed qualitative study, we explored BC-TAWs' social interactions and relations, workplace social support and how these relate to occupational well-being within the Swedish manufacturing industry. Our findings show that BC-TAWs' social interaction and relations with other BC-TAWs and client organisation employees depended on the work arrangement of the work undertaken and BC-TAWs' degree of autonomy. We identified, on the one hand, counter-supportive social interactions and relations, governed by mechanisms of mistrust, disparity and aggression, within Tayloristic work arrangements. On the other hand, we identified supportive social interactions and relations, governed by mechanisms of trust, relatedness and care, within the semi- and non-Tayloristic work arrangements. Among BC-TAWs, emotional social support was identified to be related to well-being through norms of reliability and friendliness. Instrumental social support was related to looking after one another and asks for help. Informational social support was related to being able to ask for help with instructions or problems. In addition, supportive social interactions favoured occupational well-being.

Our findings are in line with Håkansson and Isidorsson (2012), showing that Tayloristic work arrangements impaired BC-TAWs social interaction and social relations, and, in line with Bosmans, De Cuyper, et al. (2015), Bosmans, Hardonk, et al. (2015), impaired workplace social support and occupational well-being. However, in line with Bosmans et al. (2017), social support from other BC-TAWs played an important role, but, support from client organisation employees was even more important. Emotional social support that may exist in such relations seemed to enable BC-TAWs affective well-being, e.g. coping with the situation, rather than offering either help or know-how (instrumental or informational workplace social support).

BC-TAWs experienced the lack of autonomy and social interaction in Tayloristic work arrangements, as counter-supportive interactions and relations impaired experienced relatedness and trust in other BC-TAWs and client organisation employees. In line with the findings of Hall (2016), we could identify the underlying mechanisms of mistrust, disparity and aggression among BC-TAWs. We also found, in line with Underhill and Quinlan (2011), that this impaired affective and professional well-being by feelings of job insecurity and fear of being replaced.

On the other hand, semi and non-Tayloristic work arrangements enabled BC-TAWs' social interaction with other workers and, thus, typically gave rise to supportive social relations, governed by underlying identified mechanisms of trust, relatedness and care. These supportive social relations were shown through inclusion, joking and camaraderie prevail among BC-TAWs. In line with this Georganta and Montgomery (2022), we found such relations to be beneficial for all dimensions of occupational well-being, and something every employer should strive for. In such contexts, all dimensions of workplace social support, emotional, instrumental and informational will increase affective cognitive and professional BC-TAW occupational well-being.

This study in many ways show how BC-TAWs' occupational well-being is constituted by a fulfilment of basic psychological needs of autonomy, relatedness, and competence (Ryan & Deci, 2017). Confirming Giunchi et al. (2015) and Liden et al. (2003), we show how client organisation employees' workplace social support benefits BC-TAW's commitment to mutual well-being and care for other workers, which is important for client organisations to consider when hiring BC-TAWs. Equally, in line with this Cicellin

et al. (2022 and Coyle-Shapiro et al. (2006), we show how inclusive and supportive interaction (reciprocity) develops attachment to the client organisation and its employees.

4.1. Strengths, limitations and future research

A strength of this study is its contribution to existing research on social interaction, workplace social support and occupational well-being by addressing aspects of different work arrangements within the manufacturing industry and their impact on BC-TAWs. We believe that our findings show a consistency of patterns and events within similar work arrangements across several different organisations which suggests that the results are internally and externally valid.

Our study isn't flawless and faces limitations. Interviewees were recruited through the union, and participants were from client organisations that allowed them to participate in the interviews during working hours. Thus, these organisations may prioritise a good work environment and, consequently, reported data may be biased towards contexts favourable to BC-TAWs regarding work environment.

We recommend that the supportive effects of social interaction and inclusion of BC-TAW should be further researched, as it may guide and support client organisations in the development of healthy, safe and sustainable work environments (Mitlacher, 2008). We have yet to understand the differences, if they exist, in perceived social support and well-being with respect to aspects of age, gender, ethnicity and group dynamics, that is, what role does the group composition play for BC-TAWs' perceived workplace social support and its implications on their occupational well-being? More research is needed within the tradition of positive psychology.

5. Conclusion

Our study has filled a previously identified research gap and the need to study the work arrangements to understand how BC-TAWs' occupational well-being can be enhanced and results showed the importance of workplace social interaction for BC-TAW workplace social support and occupational well-being.

In Tayloristic work arrangements, the social interaction was scarce and even counter-supportive, governed by underlying mechanisms mistrust, disparity and aggression, which increased the risk of perceived lack of influence and exhaustion. In semi- and non-Tayloristic work arrangements, social interaction was supportive, and governed by underlying mechanisms of trust, relatedness and care, which fostered emotional, instrumental and informational workplace social support. In addition, workplace social support was found beneficial for perceived physical and social well-being at work, in particular when BC-TAWs had longer assignments, wore the same clothes and thereby constituted a more permanent part of the client organisation workforce.

In terms of practical implications, our results suggest that organisations should strive for semi- and non-Tayloristic work arrangements to promote BC-TAWs and other workers' well-being and, thereby, possibly also the organisational production. Tayloristic work arrangements, minimising social interaction, may be counterproductive, and organisations should carefully consider implications on workers' occupational well-being and the organisation's safety climate when hiring BC-TAWs.

Ethical approval

This qualitative study, following the ALLEA (2017) code of conduct for research integrity, was approved by the Swedish Ethical Review Authority (Ref No 2019, 06220; 2022-05554-02).

Author contribution

Andreas Kjörling: Contributing to conception, design, acquisition of data, data analysis, interpretation of data, and writing the paper.

Tuukka Kaidesoja: Contributing to conception, acquisition of data, design, data analysis, interpretation of data, and critical revision of the paper for intellectual content.

Eva L. Bergsten: Contributing to conception, acquisition of data, design, data analysis, interpretation of data, and critical revision of the paper for intellectual content.

Disclosure statement

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Data availability statement

Due to the nature of the research and ethical restrictions, supporting data are not available; any further underlying data will be made available upon reasonable request.

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